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The New York Times



MADDIE MCGARVEY FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Radioactive Brine Imperils a City’s Drinking Water
Bob Wilson found fracking wastewater bubbling up in Marietta, Ohio. It was supposed to stay deep underground forever. Page A12.

Sea Captives: Strikes Snare 6,000 Sailors

By JENNY GROSS and PETER EAVIS

GENEVA — Trapped on a commercial ship anchored four miles off Iran’s coast, about two dozen merchant seamen are entering their fourth month of living under the watch of Iranian guards.

Iran seized the vessel, the MSC Francesca, as it tried to pass through the Strait of Hormuz on April 22. Its sailors are from Montenegro, Indonesia, the Philippines and other countries. All are far from home. They have no idea when they might be released and have had very little contact with the outside world.

The sailors “have no means of communication except every several days 30 min of internet,” a person familiar with conditions on the Francesca wrote.

The crew members of the Francesca are a subset of a much larger group of sailors in harm’s way in the Middle East. The attacks by the United States and Israel on Feb. 28, followed by Iran’s closure of the Strait of Hormuz, immediately stranded some 1,500 ships and nearly 20,000 sailors, according to the International Maritime Organization.

Many ships have sailed out of the Persian Gulf, dashing through the strait when conditions have allowed. Roughly 6,000 sailors remain stranded, the maritime organization said. They live in peril, carrying out maintenance, look-outs and checks on cargo, with no safe way home. Iran has enforced

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WHIPLASH WAR The U.S. and Iran can’t stop cycling between conflict and negotiation. PAGE A5

As E-Bike Deaths Rise, New York Weighs 17 Bills

By STEFANOS CHEN

New York City legislative leaders on Tuesday announced a long list of proposed rules designed to better govern the use of electric bikes and scooters and crack down on illegal vehicles after a series of fatal crashes.

The plan, presented at a news conference outside City Hall, includes 17 bills that the City Council will consider this fall. The announcement begins a long process to shape the proposals, many of which are likely to face opposition from various interest groups, each with its own view of the city’s shared streets.

Some of the bills have already been introduced, including ones that would ban the sale of some faster e-bikes that are currently legal; require delivery companies to register for commercial licenses; compel those companies to share more data about drivers’ trips; curtail the use of unregistered mopeds; and support stricter penalties for riders who flee the scene of a crash.

Other legislation under consideration would mandate additional insurance for food delivery apps; ratchet up enforcement against lawbreakers and users of illegal devices that can far exceed the 15-miles-per-hour speed limit for e-bikes; and introduce a trade-in program for riders to swap illegal devices with safer ones.

Lawmakers will also consider convening a task force to study street design improvements, as well as consider requiring more detailed enforcement statistics from the Police Department.

“We cannot wait again for tragedy to strike to become advocates for public safety,” Julie Menin, the Council speaker, said on Tuesday, vowing to run a “comprehensive

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LOREN ELLIOTT FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Devastating Fires in Spokane
Whole neighborhoods were destroyed and thousands forced to evacuate in Washington. Page A17.

Ronald Lauder, Billionaire and G.O.P. Funder, Closes His Wallet

By NICHOLAS FANDOS

For decades, Ronald S. Lauder, the billionaire cosmetics heir and philanthropist, has been something like a one-man bank for Republicans in New York.

He personally funded a campaign to impose term limits in New York City, helped pay for a lawsuit to overturn the state’s gerrymandered congressional map

and, just four years ago, plowed close to \$13 million into races that helped Republicans flip the House.

Now, in the middle of another crucial midterm election year, Mr. Lauder, 82, appears to have abruptly closed his political checkbook, and the ramifications for the conservative movement he has nurtured in his home state could be significant.

Leaving Financial Void for Party in New York

He has yet to make a single donation to Republicans in his home state this year, according to campaign finance records. The super PAC he long maintained to advance Republican candidates and

causes is also sitting idle.

And behind the scenes, Mr. Lauder has quietly dismissed a stable of well-paid advisers, ad makers and other consultants who regularly reported to his personal office in the Estée Lauder headquarters overlooking Central Park in Manhattan. Some had been with Mr. Lauder since 1989, when he ran his own quixotic race

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INTERNATIONAL A4-9

Leading in Science and Song
Jérôme Dupras is part of one of Quebec’s most popular folk rock bands, and is the province’s chief scientist. PAGE A4

Ferry Tragedy Exposes Rifts
Many in Guyana are asking how 100 died in an accident while the country’s oil-rich economy booms. PAGE A7

ON THE WEB

Competitive Primaries
Contests kicked off in five states, including Michigan’s Democratic Senate race. Coverage is at nytimes.com.

NATIONAL A10-20

Trump’s Intrusive Arch
The Park Service found that a 250-foot edifice would alter views across dozens of historic sites in Washington. PAGE A10

SPORTS B7-10

Commanders Look to Daniels
Washington is counting on its returning quarterback to again dazzle. PAGE B7



FOOD D1-8

Treating Your Tomatoes Right
We have come up with seven recommendations that will help you get the most out of the summer staple. PAGE D1

Summers That Shaped a Chef
As a new film evokes Anthony Bourdain’s emergence in Provincetown, Mass., we revisit the town. PAGE D1

BUSINESS B1-6

What Do Firms Get From A.I.?
A new field of “tokenomics” has emerged to measure the return on all of the money companies are pouring into artificial intelligence. PAGE B1

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Fame vs. Health and Privacy
Ariana Grande has long pushed back on comments about her weight loss, urging fans to be “gentler.” As her profile grew, so did the scrutiny. PAGE C1

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Ezra Klein PAGE A22

THE WEATHER
Today, humid, afternoon thunderstorm in spots, high 81. Tonight, very humid, a storm in spots, low 72. Tomorrow, some sun, a storm, high 88. Weather map is on Page A20.

BLANCHE CLEARS CRUCIAL HURDLE TO CONFIRMATION

MOVES TO FULL SENATE

Widening Schism Is Seen in Party-Line Vote for Attorney General

By GLENN THRUSH and MICHAEL GOLD

WASHINGTON — Todd Blanche, whose role in a much-criticized deal to resolve President Trump’s lawsuit against the I.R.S. nearly scuttled his confirmation as attorney general, cleared a crucial hurdle on Tuesday after the Senate Judiciary Committee narrowly approved his nomination.

After a week of uncertainty, Mr. Blanche was confirmed by a 12-to-10 vote along party lines, exemplifying a widening schism over the direction of a department at the center of Mr. Trump’s effort to



Todd Blanche reached a deal with two Republican holdouts.

punish and humiliate his perceived enemies.

Mr. Blanche, the president’s former defense lawyer and the acting attorney general, broke an impasse over his confirmation after he reached an agreement with two Republican holdouts on the committee late Sunday. Mr. Blanche released written assurances that he would kill a proposed \$1.8 billion compensation fund that could have been used to pay Jan. 6 rioters and limit the scope of a deal granting broad tax immunity to Mr. Trump and his family.

Mr. Blanche’s nomination now advances to the Senate floor, with a vote possible as early as this week. It was not immediately

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One Lawyer’s Sisyphean Battle To Help Trans Troops Fight Ban

By GREG JAFFE and DAVE PHILLIPS

She had lost 26 of her last 27 cases, a string of defeats and disappointments unlike anything she had experienced in her legal career.

“It’s my first time getting kicked in the face over and over,” Priya Rashid was telling another lawyer over the phone.

She looked over at client No. 28, who was sitting in a hearing room where a separation board would soon decide whether to force him to leave the military. He was a 33-year-old transgender Army captain named Kai Proce.

He grimaced at the thought of what was to come.

“Sorry,” Ms. Rashid said.

Last year, Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth issued an order that effectively forced all trans troops out of the military. Many of the more than 4,000 who were serving accepted that the Pentagon was going to force them out and took a cash payout to leave quickly.

But others decided to stay and fight, taking their cases to special



Priya Rashid before a separation hearing, held secretly.

separation boards set up by the military.

The boards operate like court proceedings, with lawyers and a panel of three officers who decide whether to retain or remove the service member. It is the same process the military uses to determine whether it should kick out troops who abuse drugs, beat their spouses or steal.

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OBITUARIES B11-12

A Creator of Intense Dances
Paul Sanasardo had a dreamlike, expressionistic style that influenced the theatrical works of the choreographer Pina Bausch. He was 97. PAGE B11

